

SELLER RESOURCES

Pre-Listing Cabin Prep Checklist

What to do, in order, in the eight weeks before you list a Minnesota cabin or lake home.

MinnesotaLakeHomesForSale.com · Updated May 2026

How to use this

Cabins look smaller and rougher in photos than they do in person. The work in this checklist closes that gap. Run it in order, starting eight weeks out from your target listing date. Most of it is cheap — the value is in doing it before the photographer arrives, not after the listing has stalled.

Eight weeks out — Spring open-up

- Water system de-winterized and pressurized; check every fixture for leaks
- Hot-water heater on, cycled, and checked
- All toilets flushed, traps refilled, slow drains snaked
- Furnace serviced and filter replaced
- AC / window units tested and clean
- Refrigerator on, ice maker working, stale food removed
- Inspect for winter rodent activity and remediate
- Walk every interior wall — moisture stains, ceiling stains, soft spots

Seven weeks out — Septic, well, and compliance

- Septic pumped within last 3 years; if not, pump now
- Septic Certificate of Compliance ordered (county-required at sale or transfer in most lakeshore counties)
- Well water tested for total coliform, E. coli, nitrates
- Iron / manganese tested if treatment system present
- Service / inspect water softener, filtration, RO if installed
- Holding-tank service contract in writing if applicable

Six weeks out — Shoreline, dock, and waterfront

- Dock installed and leveled; remove last winter's storage
- Boat lift in, canopy in good shape, mechanism working

- Swim raft / mooring whips deployed
- Shoreline walked for visible erosion, exposed roots, undercut soil
- Riprap re-set if any rocks have shifted (DIY for small touch-ups, contractor for larger)
- Sandblanket raked, weed line trimmed within shoreland-rule limits
- Dock and shoreline lights replaced and operational
- Lake-side stairs or paths inspected for frost heave damage

Five weeks out — Exterior

- Roof inspected; missing shingles or ice-dam damage repaired
- Gutters cleaned and pitched correctly (lakeside is usually the worst)
- Lake-facing siding washed; mildew on north side cleaned
- Lake-facing wood (deck, railings, trim) re-stained or touched up
- Windows washed inside and out — especially lake-facing glass
- Storm windows / doors operate and close cleanly
- Exterior lights working; replace any cool-blue LEDs with warm-white for photo day
- Driveway raked, regraded, or fresh gravel as needed

Four weeks out — Declutter and depersonalize

Cabins photograph small

Cut visible occupancy by 40%. The remaining 60% should look like a magazine — not a home, not a storage shed.

- Personal photos and family portraits removed (or boxed)
- Fishing gear, snowmobile boots, hunting gear stored off-site or in garage
- Closet contents culled to 50% of capacity (buyers open closets)
- Refrigerator magnets and notes down
- Hooks, hats, coats reduced to 2–3 visible items max
- Mounted fish, taxidermy, antlers — keep one as character; remove the rest
- Rugs vacuumed, beat outside; stained rugs replaced or removed
- Bookshelves pruned to 60% capacity, books straightened

Three weeks out — Stage for photo day

- Beds made, neutral linens (white, cream, light gray) — buy if needed
- Towels matched and folded tightly in every bath
- Kitchen counters cleared except 2–3 items (coffee, fruit bowl, small plant)
- Lakeside deck staged: 2 chairs + small table; nothing else
- Dock staged: pair of Adirondack chairs facing the water
- Indoor and outdoor cushions cleaned or replaced
- Fresh flowers or a low arrangement on the dining table for photo day
- Empty all trash and recycling 90 minutes before the photographer arrives

Three weeks out — Mechanicals and small repairs

- Switch plates and outlet covers replaced where chipped or yellowed
- Light bulbs all matched (warm white, 2700K) — varying color temps photograph badly
- Dripping faucets, running toilets, sticky doors fixed
- Caulking refreshed in lake-facing baths and kitchen
- Touch-up paint on visible scuffs (lakeside walls take the most sun)
- Locks rekey-ready or noted for closing checklist
- Smoke and CO detectors in every bedroom and on every level (MN code)

Two weeks out — Photography day

- Confirm photographer's drone weather window 48 hours out
- All vehicles off the property and out of the driveway during the shoot
- Boats and lifts in place, tarps off, canopies up
- Lakeside grill cleaned or covered (cleaner photographs better)
- Dock chairs facing the water, staged exactly as they'll be in listing photos
- Lights on inside the house; warm-light bulbs in lakeside lamps for dusk shots
- Pets and people off the property during the shoot

One week out — Listing-ready

- Listing copy reviewed and approved
- Septic compliance certificate, well log, water test results in writing and ready for buyer
- Lake-association covenants, dues schedule, and shared-use rules in a folder
- Past two years of property-tax statements ready
- Past two years of utility costs (electric, propane, internet) ready
- Recent receipts for major repairs, dock work, septic work in a folder
- Showing instructions and lockbox plan confirmed with listing agent
- Schedule cleaning service for first showing day

Day before listing

- Final walk-through with listing agent
- Lakeside windows wiped one more time
- All trash + recycling out
- Beds made, kitchen counters clear, towels matched
- Lights on a timer for evening drive-bys
- Lockbox installed and tested
- Any pets and pet evidence (food, water bowls, beds) staged out of sight

Common items that show up too late

- **Septic non-compliance.** Buyers' inspectors will catch it. Get the certificate in hand before listing.
- **Roof and ice-dam damage.** Especially common after February ice events; spring photos hide it but inspections don't.
- **Shoreline erosion.** Even small areas read as "liability" in photos and inspection reports.
- **Permit gaps.** Sandblanket, dock, deck-expansion, accessory-structure permits — find them now, not at closing.

Companion resources

Minnesota Lake Home Seller Guide · Seller's Net Proceeds Calculator · Seller Disclosure Reference (MN). All available at MinnesotaLakeHomesForSale.com/resources.

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